

CHASE HAMPTON (#44), NEW YORK YANKEES

Level: AA (Somerset Patriots)

Position(s): RHP

Age: 24

B/T: R/R

Dates Seen: 6/12/26

Projected Role: Depth Starter

Ceiling: Mid-rotation Starter

Floor: Swingman/Bulk Relief Arm

Report: 2026 Preseason

Org Rk	Ovr Rk	ETA	FV
8	N/A	2027	45
Fastball	Slider	Curveball	
40 / 45	55 / 60	55 / 60	
Cutter	Command		
45 / 50	40 / 45		

Delivery

Hampton made his first official AA start on 6/12 after six rehab starts in the lower minors as he came back from Tommy John surgery. With the first start back from a major surgery like Tommy John, and given Hampton's injury history, it's important to let Hampton get his feet under him on his way back. At 6'2, 225 pounds, Hampton is a sturdy body with a high $\frac{3}{4}$ arm angle. Hampton starts from a full windup, with his hands by his belt, and finishes over his front leg with a strong, upright chest. Hampton has a fluid, repeatable motion, with a medium leg kick, before slightly falling off toward first base.

Arsenal

Hampton still displayed a strong feel for his sweeper on 6/12. Hampton struck 3 consecutive batters out, all with his sweeper, with all hitters expanding out of the zone. He went to the sweeper with runners on 1st and 2nd with nobody out. He effectively mixed his fastball and sweeper early to keep hitters off balance before using his sweeper again as a put-away pitch. The Rumble Ponies were not seeing the sweeper through all 3 innings of work. The only hit he allowed on his sweeper was a bloop single to right that was off the end of the bat and came on a fooled 2-strike swing. The sweeper showed clear deception to get swing-and-miss, and Hampton was able to throw it for strikes when needed.

Hampton should continue to progress and improve through his starts in AA this year to return to his pre-surgery form. The key metrics to improve for him are his walk and strikeout rates. Pre-surgery, Hampton in 59.2 innings in AA had a K/9 of 10.26 with a BB/9 of 3.17, with an xFIP that year of 3.84. While it is a much smaller sample size (8 innings in AA this year), Hampton's K/9 is cut in half to 5.63, while his BB/9 is up to 4.50, leading to an xFIP of 5.52. As Hampton gains a better feel for his sweeper, curveball, and fastball command, these numbers should improve and move closer to his 2024 form. Hampton's ability to attack hitters early, limit

his walk rate, get to his offspeed pitches to increase his K/9, and limit damage will yield better results going forward.

Hampton's pitch repertoire is an area that could get him into trouble as he faces tougher competition. Hampton's repertoire is a 4-seam fastball, cutter, curveball, and a sweeper. The latter three, while having different movement profiles and varying amounts of horizontal and induced vertical break, each pitch moves laterally towards his glove side. Minus Hampton's fastball, lefties will see the cutter, curveball, and sweeper all breaking in, and righties will see the same pitches all breaking away. The cutter, curveball, and sweeper all have similar spin rates as well, averaging around 2500 RPM. Hampton's pitches are effective, and Hampton can definitely continue to progress if he tunnels his pitches effectively off each other. Being able to throw a cutter glove-side to righties, before following up with his sweeper, with the same spin rates, would be tunneled effectively to cause weak contact or a high chase. However, with the same general lateral movement, there is a chance that each pitch would not cause enough differentiation to throw off the hitter's timing. Hampton can use the lack of spin-rate difference between pitches to his advantage by tunneling each pitch off the previous one. However, if Hampton doesn't tunnel effectively or doesn't have his best stuff, hitters could sit on two pitches: the fastball and a "general pitch moving away". When hitters can eliminate specific pitches, locations, or movements, professional hitters can adjust and cause damage.

Command

Hampton was clearly struggling with feel and command on 6/12, throwing 60 pitches over 3 innings of work and even having some errant throws on pickoffs. Again, it is not unexpected for pitchers returning from Tommy John to struggle with feel and to fall behind early in counts. As he comes back from Tommy John, gets more comfortable, and builds stamina, his pitch mix will only improve in terms of strike percentage and effectiveness. The biggest area to improve upon in his next couple of starts would be to focus on first-pitch strikes to get to sweeper in more favorable counts.

In his next start, despite taking the loss and allowing 5 earned runs, Hampton showed an improved feel for his pitches in his comeback from Tommy John surgery. Hampton threw 62 pitches, 47 for strikes, good enough for a 66% strike rate. Hampton was definitely more in the strike zone compared to his first start, so it is not surprising to see him get hit around. More importantly, Hampton limited walks and attacked hitters, showing improved feel for his pitches compared to his last start.

Development Path

While his focus should be on becoming 100% comfortable on the mound after Tommy John, Hampton should look to former Yankees prospect Cam Schlittler as a blueprint for advancing his game. Schlittler entered MLB in 2025, with pitch usage data (Baseball Savant) showing a fastball at 55.9%, a cutter at 19.7%, a curveball at 14.8%, a sinker at 6.8%, a sweeper at 2.3%, and a slider at 1.2%. Schlittler displayed great potential in 2025, but his 2026 has been

unbelievable, as he contends in the AL Cy Young race. Compared to 2025, in 2026, Schlittler's pitch usage was his fastball down 11.4% to 44.5%, his cutter usage increased 6.9% to 26.6%, his curveball usage decreased 8% to 6.6%, his sinker usage increased 13.3% to 20.3%, and his slider increase .9% to 1.9%. Schlittler had a similar profile to Hampton (minus the sinker), but started to rely on the best pitch of his offspeed pitches, his cutter, while also relying on his one pitch that has the opposite horizontal break as his others (sinker). The combination of consolidating his glove-side breaking offspeed pitches and using his sinker more, Schlittler has become the dominant pitcher we see today. His improved movement profile and pitch usage have improved nearly every metric: barrel rate down 1.5%, average launch angle down 2.3 degrees, sweet spot % is down 6.7%, wOBA is down .56 points, strikeout rate up 1.9%, and walk rate is down 5.3%. Hitters are overpowered and off-balanced, unable to sit on his curveball/cutter combo, and now have to cover 3 movement profiles: high velocity fastball at the top of the zone, a sinker running down and in to righties/down and away to lefties, and his cutter breaking glove-side. Including the sinker in his profile has been the most important, as it backs hitters off the plate and prevents them from cheating on the out half of the plate against his cutter or cheating up in the zone against his good fastball. That gets hitters in between the three pitches and three movement profiles, which Hampton currently does not have.

Hampton should follow a similar progression: consolidate similar pitches to throw the most effective ones more often, and add a different movement profile to the repertoire to avoid predictability. My recommendation is for Hampton to lean more heavily on his fastball-sweeper combination, as it has shown the best movement and results, before considering adding a changeup, sinker, splitter, or any offspeed pitch with arm-side break. It will be a tough battle to combine changes to pitch usage and possibly add a new pitch while recovering from Tommy John, as pitchers returning from Tommy John need time to get that feel back in their fingertips so they can effectively use the seams of the baseball to their advantage. However, the Yankees have shown they can develop pitchers through their system, such as Luis Gil and Schlittler, and there is no saying Hampton can't be another part of that future.